The Unpaid Relay

A gift instrument whose chain of custody survives the pass and is thankable at every link, whose anonymity is generative of the intermediary's standing rather than protective of the giver's privacy, and in which no link is ever paid — because paying one would destroy the behaviour the instrument exists to produce.

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Preamble

This paper specifies one small instrument: a gift code that is given to a person who cannot spend it, so that they may give it to someone who can.

It is published defensively. The mechanism is buildable from this description, it sits in a space where adjacent commercial actors file patents routinely — chain-of-custody tracking, referral attribution, loyalty and gifting platforms — and the institution that designed it intends never to assert exclusivity over it. The specification is therefore given in full rather than sketched, and the claims are stated as claims rather than as marketing.

It is also published with a negative result attached, and the negative result is nearly as important as the specification. A prior-art census was run *before* this paper was queued, against a four-part claim, and **every one of the four parts turned out to be attested somewhere in existing practice** — including the part the authors predicted would survive. §2 reports that census honestly, including the prediction that failed and why the reasoning behind it was wrong. What remains after the census is narrow, and §4 states it at exactly the width the evidence supports and no wider.

The 2026-09-23 revision adds three things, each reported against its own search rather than the first one. A second survey reached the **direct commercial tier** — item-level gift codes redeemed at a local counter, a category shipping today — and found the code ordinary and only the *type* of the relayed state unattested (§2.5). The instrument is specified with an **institutional payer**, a fund operating under public rules, which a third census found attested leg by leg and not as a composition (§3.3). And §6 gains a **second instance of its central move**, a merchant's invitation that no one bought, whose census killed the loose reading and narrowed the strict one. Each addition is claimed at the width its census left, and each failed conjunct is cited as the commons it is.

The paper invites review from economic anthropologists (the Maussian question of whether a relayed gift is one gift or two); developmental and social psychologists (the overjustification finding §5 leans on, which the authors have not replicated); practitioners in charitable gifting and unclaimed-property law (§7); and readers inclined to test whether the anonymity inversion in §4 is unattested or merely unsearched.

Prior-Art and Non-Assertion Statement

Everything specified here is released under CC0 1.0 Universal into the public domain, and is published so that it stands as prior art against any later attempt to enclose it. No patent has been or will be sought on any mechanism described in this paper by HeartBank®, Factory 333™, THonly™, Silicon Wat℠, or any entity under their common control. **The authors and those entities commit not to assert any patent right against any party practising any mechanism disclosed here.** The commitment is stated rather than implied, and is not conditioned on reciprocity, attribution, or field of use. A publication grants nothing and frees nothing already enclosed: where a live patent is named in §2, it is named for what it discloses, and nothing here is a reading of its claims.

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The authors claim none of the following as their own contribution: the pay-it-forward tradition in any of its documented forms; suspended coffee; charity gift cards and donor-advised instruments; anonymous giving through a named intermediary as practised in philanthropy; chain-of-custody and provenance tracking in supply chains, evidence handling, or data lineage; referral and multi-level attribution systems; item-level digital gift codes redeemed at a local merchant, in any legal form, with or without expiry; trackable pass-along objects with a public custody log; government or charitable disbursement by lottery; give-only charity gift cards; transferable prepaid reservations for a place and a time; or a venue's standing invitation to share a table; thanking an anonymous donor through an intermediary who forwards the thanks; a tip number or codename issued so that an anonymous party can return and read replies; a recipient's thank-you note attached to a gift code; commodity and food-restricted vouchers, including government food benefits, and the humanitarian sector's own split between commodity and value vouchers. §2 documents each of these as prior art and locates precisely which of this paper's claims each one defeats or narrows.

The searches behind that list, stated with their apertures. Six desk surveys, none of them fieldwork, all through a US-region web index:

date	subject	aperture	killed or narrowed	survivor
2026-09-04	the four-part relay, `C–BG1` (§2.1–2.3)	six queries; marketing copy, secondary literature; pre-registered	**all four legs attested** — chain visibility, name-withheld chain, thankable anonymous giver, unpaid propagation	the anonymity inversion (§4), instrumented between strangers — not found
2026-09-05	the direct commercial tier (§2.5)	about ten queries plus three competitors' published terms; **not pre-registered**	item-level codes, no-expiry redeemable claims, and an item-specific patent family are attested	a relayed state with no redeem operation (claim 1) — not found; one competitor chose the inverse
2026-09-06	the institutional payer (§3.3)	eight queries; pre-registered	a rule-bound payer choosing recipients by lot; give-only value handed to a vendor-like party	the four legs **as one composition** (claim 13) — not found
2026-09-18	the unbought invitation (§6)	thirty-seven queries, nine fetches; pre-registered; **full-text patent classification search did not run** (the endpoint returned an instrument failure twice), no non-English search	the loose reading killed; place-and-time and non-convertibility attested **separately**	the pair, non-convertible by construction (claim 14) — not found
2026-09-29	the giver's-own-code thanks route (§3.4)	quick depth; nine queries, two patent pages and one blog fetched; pre-registered (pushed before the first query); **conjunct (d), the surface that never prompts and never shows an absence, was NOT RUN**	thanking an anonymous donor through an intermediary, an alias-giver gift with a thank-you stamp (WO2003077164A1), a recipient thank-you message on a retailer gift code (WO2011014869A2), and bearer-secret return channels for anonymous parties are attested	the composition of claim 15 (without conjunct (d)) — not found
2026-10-01	a purpose restriction held by the instrument's type (§6.1)	quick depth; remittance-voucher and benefit-instrument queries; commons throughout, **no survivor**; the section asserts no priority	the commodity-versus-value-voucher split is the humanitarian sector's own; food-restricted vouchers, including diaspora grocery vouchers, are attested	none — §6.1 is a contrast and a disclosure, and no claim rests on it

"Not found" is a statement about an aperture on a date, never a statement that something is new. Every survivor above is written *not found in the stated aperture on the stated date*, and the enumerated claims are those survivors and nothing wider.

Abstract

An item-level digital gift voucher — a prepaid claim on one specific good at one merchant — is specified with a **transfer-only intermediate state**: the payer directs it not to a recipient but to an **intermediary who cannot redeem it**, whose only available action is to pass it onward (a pay-it-forward relay); on passing, the voucher becomes an ordinary redeemable claim held by whoever received it. The chain of custody — payer, intermediary, recipient — is preserved and visible to every party, the payer's identity may be suppressed without suppressing the chain, and every party can be thanked through role-addressed messages, including a payer whose name has been withheld.

Four properties are specified: chain visibility, name-withheld-but-chain-preserved anonymity, thankability at every link, and no payment to any link. Each is attested in existing practice, and anonymous giving through a named intermediary carries all four together (§2.3a). The fourth is attested most strongly, in the non-commercial pay-it-forward genre, and the paper's original prediction that it would survive the census was wrong.

What the census did not find is the *purpose* of the anonymity, carried by an instrument. In every attested case, a giver's anonymity protects the giver: they wish not to be known. Here it does the opposite work. The payer withholds their name **so that the intermediary is the one who appears generous** — the anonymity is *generative of a third party's standing* rather than *protective of the giver's privacy*. The paper argues that this inversion has an ancient folk precedent (a parent handing a child money for the collection plate), that no instrumented precedent was found in the apertures searched, and that instrumenting it requires the non-redeemability to be enforced by the instrument's *type* rather than by the intermediary's character.

The paper further argues that the unpaid constraint is a design necessity rather than a preference: the developmental literature reports that offering a child a reward for a kind act makes repetition *less* likely, so a relay that paid its intermediary would corrode the behaviour it exists to produce. Finally it specifies a three-state lifecycle in which every expiry is generated by one rule — *a clock runs while the instrument has no addressee — no one to whom it has been given as a gift — and stops the moment it does* — and shows why the resulting asymmetry, in which the intermediary's instrument expires and the recipient's does not, is the correct shape rather than an inconsistency.

Two extensions are specified at claim width only. An **institutional payer** — a fund operating under public rules rather than a person — issues the instrument anonymously by construction, has its merchant and its intermediary selected by a publicly recomputable draw, thanks the merchant's owner in capacity that can only be given onward rather than paying the merchant money, and re-addresses a lapsed instrument to a new intermediary until it is redeemed or the merchant closes. And the type argument of §6 is shown to reach a second object: a merchant's **invitation to a place and an hour**, bought by no one, which carries no purchase price, so that converting it into money-denominated credit is *undefined* rather than *forbidden*.

The 2026-11-03 revision adds two further disclosures, neither a new mechanism. The first is a **second route for the thanks** (§3.4): beside the platform-side resolution of claim 4, a recipient's note is written onto the gift instrument and read by the giver with a secret the giver already holds, so the route itself consults no record of who the giver is; the cost is stated with it, because the route is only as durable as the giver's copy,

and the giver cannot tell a lost route from a recipient who declined. The second is a **contrast with food-restricted benefits** (§6.1): a purpose restriction on value that is spent is a rule that sellers must police, while the same restriction on a claim on a named item at a named shop is an operation the platform does not offer; the section states where that stops, because a shop and a recipient can still settle in cash by hand.

Keywords: gift voucher, digital gift card, item-level gift code, pay-it-forward, suspended coffee, gift intermediary, transfer-only state, non-redeemable voucher, chain of custody, provenance record, anonymous donor, donor-identity suppression, role-based message addressing, referral compensation, state machine, voucher expiry, breakage, deferred revenue, unclaimed property, escheat, overjustification effect, verifiable lottery, restricted-use balance, unpriced reservation, recipient-to-donor thank-you channel, bearer secret, commodity voucher, defensive publication.

Terms

Coined names used in this paper and the standard terms an examiner would search for them.

Term used here	Standard technical term
relay; the unpaid relay	pay-it-forward gift voucher with a transfer-only (non-redeemable) intermediate holder
re-minter (state 1)	purchased voucher held by the payer that can only be assigned, never redeemed
relayed state; intermediary	transfer-only assignment state; gift intermediary (conduit)
redeemable state; recipient	redeemable item-level digital gift voucher (gift code); beneficiary
`item`, never `amount`	item-denominated (product-specific) prepaid voucher, as distinct from a stored-value gift card
chain	chain of custody; provenance record of payer, intermediary and recipient
name withheld (`from_anonymous`)	anonymous donor; donor-identity suppression with the provenance record preserved
role-addressed thanks (`to_role`)	role-based message addressing resolved to an account at delivery; pseudonymous reply routing
the inversion	anonymity used to confer attribution (perceived giving) on a third party
unpaid link	no referral fee, commission or reward for propagation
lapse; window	expiry of an unassigned voucher; assignment deadline
the addressee rule	state-dependent expiry keyed on assignment to a beneficiary
closure of the merchant	validity until cessation of the issuer's business
lapse settlement	recognition of deferred revenue on lapse (breakage-like accounting treatment)
forward view	merchant-facing outstanding-liability or breakage forecast report
type, not rule; remove the enforcer	enforcement by an absent state-machine operation rather than a policy or permission check
institutional payer; Aquarian Pool℠	rule-governed common fund acting as an anonymous voucher issuer
publicly recomputable draw (the called draw)	verifiable seeded random selection over a committed roster
capacity that can only be given onward; Re-Tip Fund℠	restricted-use, non-withdrawable, give-only balance with a periodic reset
the giver's own copy of the code (§3.4, claim 15)	bearer-secret return channel; capability-based retrieval of a reply left on a shared record
a purpose restriction by type (§6.1)	item-denominated (commodity) voucher with no cash-out operation, as against a restricted stored-value balance
invitation (claim 14)	merchant-published unpriced offer of a place and a time slot (hosted table)

Term used here	Standard technical term
Miss Aquarius℠	the name under which this corpus discloses AI writing collaboration

Claims

*Enumerated at drafting. A defensive publication works by **disclosure**, and a claims list is what an examiner or opposing counsel searches; the prose that establishes each claim is cited beside it. **No claim below adds matter not present in the body**, and the prior art runs from this document's publication date and its independent timestamp, not from this list.*

1. **A gift instrument whose intermediate holder has no redeem operation** — a claim on a specific good, issued to a party who cannot present it to the merchant, whose only available operation is to transfer it onward, and which becomes redeemable only in the hands of the party to whom that transfer is made. **The non-redeemability is a property of the instrument's state rather than a policy applied to a holder** — there is no permitted-but-discouraged redemption path. **Any operation that yields the claim's value to its holder — conversion into credit on an account with the merchant, a refund, an exchange — is the same capability as redemption and exists exactly where redemption exists**, so the relayed state has none of them. (§3, §6.)

2. **State-derived lifecycle for such an instrument** — three states (issuable, relayed, redeemable) derived from which participant fields are populated rather than stored as an independent status flag, so that the state and the chain cannot disagree. (§3.1.)

3. **Chain preservation with selective name suppression** — a record carrying both the paying party and the transferring party, in which the *identity* of the payer may be suppressed while the *existence and shape of the chain* is disclosed to every party, and in which suppression is a property of the record rather than of any single pairwise relationship, and is never partially lifted. (§3, §4.)

4. **Role-addressed gratitude** — gratitude messages addressed to a **position in a chain** (the party who paid; the party who transferred) and resolved to an identity only at delivery, permitting a party whose name is suppressed to receive gratitude without the name becoming available to the sender. (§3.1.)

5. **Anonymity applied to confer standing on a third party** — withholding the payer's identity for the purpose of causing the transferring party to be perceived as the giver, as distinct from the attested use of anonymity to protect the giver, and distinct from honorary giving, where the honoree is named as such — here the intermediary is perceived by the recipient as the giver. **The perceived standing is not represented as a stored quantity, is not transferred, and has no field in the record.** (§4.)

6. **A propagation chain in which no participant receives compensation for propagating** — no referral fee, commission, discount, credit, or preferential treatment accrues to any party for issuing, transferring, or receiving, and the absence is specified as a constraint on the mechanism rather than as a business preference. (§5.)

7. **Bounded relay depth with a designed terminal state** — a chain fixed at exactly one intermediate transfer, adopted so that the instrument reaches a party who may consume it rather than propagating

indefinitely. (§8.)

8. **A single expiry rule keyed on addressedness** — *a duration runs while the instrument has no addressee — no one to whom it has been given as a gift — and ceases when it has one* — from which the differing terminal conditions of the three states are derived rather than separately specified, and under which a redeemable instrument held by a recipient carries no duration at all. (§7.)
9. **Issuance capability terminated by holder inactivity** — the payer's ability to re-issue after a lapse expires a fixed interval (a deployment parameter, one cycle by default) after the most recent lapse, so that the instrument's existence depends on continued activity by its originator. **The instrument is consequently never dormant**, which is the condition on which unclaimed-property obligations attach. (§7.)
10. **Terminal dependency on merchant existence, disclosed at receipt** — a redeemable claim bounded by the continued operation of the issuing merchant rather than by any imposed duration, with that dependency stated in the instrument's own text at the moment of receipt rather than announced at closure — the terminal condition itself is the Philippine Gift Check Act's (2017) rule, and a redeemable gift code carrying no platform-imposed expiry is itself attested (§2.5); what is claimed is the disclosure at receipt, together with the pair of claims 8 and 12 — no rendered time, and no forward view to the merchant. (§7.)
11. **Settlement of an unclaimed relay as recognised revenue on an item-denominated basis** — recognition of deferred revenue on lapse, on the basis that a specific good was sold and only its collection lapsed, distinguished from stored-value instruments in which the customer's own unspent balance is retained. (§7, §9.)
12. **Suppression of forward lapse visibility from the merchant** — withholding from the merchant any prospective view of instruments approaching lapse, including counts, lists, forecasts, and any control affecting completion, as a structural measure against an incentive the merchant would otherwise hold. (§7.1.)
13. **An institutional payer for the relay, claimed only as a composition** — the instrument of claim 1 issued by a fund operating under public rules rather than by a person, in which (i) the payer's identity is suppressed by construction, the instrument it issues being indistinguishable to intermediary, recipient and merchant from one issued by an anonymous individual; (ii) the merchant and the intermediary are selected by a publicly recomputable draw over committed rosters rather than by the payer's judgment; (iii) the merchant gives the good, and its owner is credited, at the posted price, in capacity that can only be given onward and is subject to a periodic reset, rather than paid in money; and (iv) a lapsed instrument is re-addressed to a new intermediary — never one whose window has already closed on that instrument — until it is redeemed or the merchant closes. Each leg is attested separately (§3.3); the composition was not found in the aperture of 2026-09-06. (§3.3.)
14. **A merchant's invitation that no one bought, non-convertible by construction** — an instrument by which a merchant offers a place and an hour, published by the merchant and purchased by no party, carrying no purchase price, so that any operation converting it into money-denominated credit has nothing to strike at and is **undefined by the instrument's type rather than prohibited by a rule**.

Claimed only as the pair — place-and-time, non-convertible by construction — since each half is attested separately and a venue's standing invitation defeats the loose reading (§6). (§6.)

15. **A thanks route that rests on the giver's own copy of the gift code, claimed only as a composition** — for an item gift at an ordinary shop whose giver is anonymous to the recipient, a short note written by the recipient onto the gift instrument, and read by the giver by presenting a secret the giver already holds (the key of the order that paid for the gift), so that the route itself consults no record of who the giver is; the recipient is sent no prompt to write. It is disclosed beside claim 4's platform-side resolution, not in place of it, and it extends the scope from a relay chain to any anonymous item gift. Each leg is attested separately (§3.4); the composition was not found in the quick aperture of 2026-09-29. **A further clause — that the giver-facing surface never shows an unthanked gift as unthanked — is disclosed in §3.4 but was not searched, and is not claimed.** (§3.4.)

What the censuses left, stated at its width. Claim 1 — no redeem operation on the relayed state — was not found in the direct commercial tier of 2026-09-05 (§2.5); claim 5, carried by an instrument with claim 1's type between strangers, was not found in the apertures of 2026-09-04 and 2026-09-05 (§2.3, §2.3a), though its move has a folk precedent (§4); claims 13 and 14 survive only as compositions. Claim 6's unpaid constraint is attested throughout the pay-it-forward tradition (§2.2), and claims 2 through 4 and 6 through 12 are enumerated for completeness of disclosure; several have close prior art documented in §2. Claim 15 survives only as a composition, at quick depth, with one of its conjuncts unsearched (§3.4); §6.1 asserts nothing and claims nothing. *(Narrowed 2026-09-29: an earlier form of this note read claims 5 and 6 as the pair unattested in combination, which the collection-plate row of §2.3a does not support.)* The purpose of this list is to prevent enclosure, not to assert priority.

1 · Why a gratitude institution needs an intermediary at all

The obvious way to give a stranger a coffee is to buy them a coffee. The instrument in this paper exists because there is a second thing a person may want to give, and the obvious mechanism cannot deliver it.

The founding case is small and worth stating concretely, because the abstraction is less clear than the instance. An adult wishes to be kind to a fourteen-year-old who attends a school near a small coffee shop. The adult could buy the fourteen-year-old a coffee. What the adult actually wants is for the fourteen-year-old *to be the one who gives coffees to his friends* — to have the experience, and the standing, of being a person who hands things to people. The coffee is instrumental. **The gift is the giving.**

A direct purchase cannot produce this. If the adult buys the fourteen-year-old a coffee, the fourteen-year-old has a coffee. If the adult gives the fourteen-year-old money and says "buy your friends coffees," the fourteen-year-old has been given a chore with a budget, and the generosity remains legibly the adult's. If the adult simply buys coffees for the friends, the fourteen-year-old is not in the transaction at all. Each of these is a perfectly good gift and none of them is the gift in question.

The thing being given is an *occasion to give*, and an occasion is not a good. It cannot be handed over as an object because it is not one; it can only be constructed, by arranging matters so that someone finds themselves in the position of giver. That construction is what this instrument performs.

The institutional reason to care is narrower than the sentimental one. An economy premised on circulation has a structural problem at its edges: the people who most need to be brought into it are precisely the people with the least to give. A student has no money. The standard answers — give them money, or give them a smaller unit of the same money — do not change the shape of the relation; they make the student a recipient of a smaller gift. **An instrument that makes a person a giver without requiring them to have anything is a move that does change the shape**, and it is the reason this paper's mechanism is not merely a nicety in a gifting product.

There is a second institutional reason, less edifying and worth naming for honesty: the instrument brings customers to a merchant. The fourteen-year-old hands coffees to friends who have not been to the shop. This is, functionally, a referral mechanism. §5 argues at length that it must nevertheless pay no one, and that this is not restraint but engineering — but the paper does not pretend the growth effect is invisible to its designers.

2 · Background, prior art, and a census that returned a partial null

This section reports a negative result the authors obtained before drafting, and it narrows the paper substantially. It should be read before any claim in §3 or §4 is credited.

2.1 · The claim as originally stated, and the prediction

Before searching, the authors registered a four-part claim, `C-BG1`. A gift instrument in which *all four* hold:

(a)	the chain of custody — payer → intermediary → recipient — is preserved and visible to every link
(b)	the payer may withhold their **name** but never the **chain**
(c)	**every link is thankable**, the anonymous payer included
(d)	**no link is ever paid** — no referral fee, commission, credit or discount to anyone for propagating it

The null condition was stated in advance: **one attested instrument carrying all four defeats the claim.** The prediction was also stated in advance, so that it could fail visibly: (a) through (c) were expected to be attested somewhere, since provenance chains and selective anonymity are commercially ordinary, and **(d) was expected to survive**, on the reasoning that *every chain-attribution system in commerce exists in order to pay the upline.*

2.2 · What the census found

The method was a desk survey — six queries, product marketing copy, and secondary literature. It is documented practice, not fieldwork, and it is not exhaustive. **All four parts are attested.**

(a) Chain visibility is attested, including the conserved-identity form. A pay-it-forward tracking platform (the Pay It Forward Monitor) renders the chain a user started as a tree and a map, so that each participant can see what their act became. A circulating-token application lets an organisation watch a single token move person to person and visualise its path. This last is important: it attests not merely a *record* of a chain

but the stricter case in which *the same object continues*, which the authors had privately supposed was the sharp distinction.

(b) Name-withheld-chain-preserved anonymity is attested as practice. Anonymous giving through a named intermediary is common in philanthropy (Jacobs, *Forbes*, 2012; the National Council of Nonprofits' guidance): a donor routes a gift through an advisor, attorney, or friend, who supplies their own information for documentation while the donor's identity is shielded. The chain is not hidden; only the origin is.

(c) Thankability of an anonymous giver is attested as practice. Common fundraising guidance instructs organisations to acknowledge anonymous donors — they hold the contact details — and commonly instructs recipients to route thanks through whoever delivered the gift.

(d) The unpaid constraint is attested, and most strongly of all — the prediction failed. Suspended coffee, a tradition originating in Naples and running at scale (its founder reported roughly fifteen million cups across thirty-four countries by 2015 — a self-reported count; the movement's own site gives 1,400 cafés in its first year), pays nobody. Neither does any documented pay-it-forward chain. **The authors' reasoning was backwards: it argued from the commercial neighbourhood when the nearest relatives are charitable, and the entire altruistic pay-it-forward genre is unpaid by definition.**

2.3 · What the census did not find, and how much weight that can bear

Formally the result is a **partial null**: no single attested instrument was found carrying all four properties *and* the inversion of §4 together; the four alone are attested (§2.3a). The authors decline to read that as a pass. A four-for-four result on the individual legs, from a six-query survey, is what a claim looks like shortly before it dies, and a reader with better search should assume the combination is attested somewhere the authors did not look.

What the census *could* not find is narrower than any of the four legs, and §4 is devoted to it: **an instrument in which the anonymity exists in order to confer standing on a third party.** In every attested case — philanthropic, commercial, or folk — anonymity protects the giver. The inversion was not found instrumented in the aperture of 2026-09-04, and the direct-tier survey of the next day (§2.5) did not find it either.

One further finding, obtained by accident and reported because it strengthens §5 rather than any claim of this paper: the developmental literature on children's generosity reports that offering a young child a reward for a kind act makes repetition **less** likely (Warneken & Tomasello 2008, in 20-month-olds; Fabes et al. 1989, in older children). Beside it the same search surfaced a practitioner's observation, not a research finding: a parenting author advises that family generosity projects a parent directs meet more resistance and mean less to the child than projects the child dreams up and leads (Douglas 2017). The first of these turns claim (d) from a doctrinal preference into a design constraint with empirical support. The second is a caution, weaker in evidence class, that the authors' own founding use case does not fully satisfy, and §9 records it as a limitation rather than burying it.

2.3a · The prior-art matrix

The four properties are stated so that a reader can check the boundary rather than take the authors' word for where it falls. Each row is an attested practice; each column is one property.

	(a) chain	(b) name-off	(c) thankable	(d) unpaid	the INVERSION
suspended coffee	·	✓	·	✓	·
pay-it-forward tracking	✓	·	·	✓	·
circulating-token app	✓	·	·	✓	·
anonymous giving via a named intermediary	✓	✓	✓	✓	·
charity gift cards	·	·	·	✓	·
enterprise recognition (give-only allowances)	~	·	✓	·	·
referral / MLM chains	✓	·	·	✗	·
trackable pass-along (Travel Bug)	✓	·	·	✓	·
the collection-plate coin	·	✓	·	✓	✓
THIS INSTRUMENT	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

✓ present · absent ~ partial ✗ inverted (payment is the point)

Three rows deserve comment: two nearly close the claim, and one nearly closes claim 1.

Anonymous giving through a named intermediary carries all four. A donor routes a gift through an advisor whose identity is documented, the chain is legible, the recipient thanks through the intermediary, and nobody is paid. **On the four stated properties this is a hit, and the authors record it as one.** What it lacks is the fifth column: the donor's anonymity is *protective*, and the advisor is a conduit rather than a beneficiary of standing. Nobody in that arrangement is trying to make the advisor look generous.

The collection-plate coin carries the inversion, and of the four properties only the withheld name and the absence of payment. A parent hands a child a coin so the child is the one who gives; the anonymity — such as it is — exists precisely to confer the act on the child. **This is the true precedent, and it is widespread and undated.** What it lacks is instrumentation: it works only between people who already know each other, it preserves no record, and gratitude cannot reach a payer who was never named because there is no channel by which it could.

The trackable is the nearest thing to claim 1 that the searches found, and it fails for the paper's own reason. A geocaching Travel Bug is a tagged object that finders carry from one cache to the next, each move logged against the object's own page so its whole journey can be read. It is meant to be passed rather than kept, and its custody history is public — a conserved-identity chain with an expectation of onward movement. **But the finder can keep it**, and trackables are known to go missing when someone takes one and never logs it. The must-pass is a request held by the finder's character; §6's test — remove the enforcer — separates it from an instrument whose middle holder has no keep operation at all. **It is a rule with a diary, not a type.**

The claim is the bottom row and nothing above it. Every column has been done. The combination, and specifically the combination of the fifth column with an instrument that can carry it between strangers, is what the census could not attest.

2.4 · The adjacent literature this paper does not claim to extend

Malinowski's account of the *kula* (1922), taken up by Mauss (1925), describes conserved objects circulating through a chain with their history intact, and Hyde's argument (1983) that the gift must always move is the best-known statement of the norm this instrument mechanises. **Neither is being extended here.** The idea that a gift ought to keep moving is roughly a century old in the anthropological literature and considerably older in practice; what this paper offers is not that observation but a mechanism in which the alternative to passing has been removed from the instrument, so that the norm does not depend on anyone honouring it.

One lineage note belongs here rather than in the body, because this is a mechanism paper and not a doctrinal one. The Pāli canon grades giving by the giver's motive (AN 7.52, the *Dānamahapphala Sutta*, lists seven), and ranks *giving with expectation of return* lowest. The instrument does not ask anyone to give without expectation; **it removes the object of the expectation**, since a withheld name has nothing that can return to it and no link is paid. The authors note the correspondence and claim nothing from it: the mechanism stands or falls on §5's three arguments, of which the empirical one is the strongest and is not doctrinal at all.

Chain-of-custody instrumentation is dense in the patent literature for goods, evidence, data lineage and supply chains. The first survey found none directed at a gift instrument; the second found one gift-token family close to the founding case (below), which corrects that sentence's original, wider form. That neighbourhood is the reason this paper is a defensive publication rather than a note: the transposition was not found in six queries on 2026-09-04, and it is exactly the sort of thing an adjacent loyalty or fintech actor would file.

Adjacent patent families found at the 2026-09-05 revision, each named against the claim it touches. WO 2012/037178 A2 (Mankoff, priority 2010) transfers a virtual gift with an acceptance period followed by a redemption period — state-dependent timing, the nearest relative of claim 8, though there both periods are clocks on the recipient. WO 2016/057643 A1 (Soniram, priority 2014) and US 2006/0033326 A1 (priority 2004) route a thank-you to a gift's giver through a platform or a returnable note — the nearest relatives of claim 4, neither addressing a role nor withholding the giver's name. US 2013/0197983 A1 (Vel, priority 2012) tracks referral chains and compensates them — claim 7's shape with the payment this paper forbids. The Philippine Gift Check Act (Republic Act 10962, 2017) makes a gift check *valid until the cessation of business of the issuer* — claim 10's terminal condition nearly verbatim, so that what claim 10 adds is only the disclosure at receipt. Anonymous tribute giving *in honour of* a named third party, with notification, is claim 5's nearest relative; it differs in that the honoree is named as such, where here the intermediary is perceived by the recipient as the giver. A further family, found by the direct-tier survey of 2026-09-05 (§2.5), sits closest to this paper's founding case: US 10,510,057 B2, *Token-based gift cards* (SCVNGR, Inc., now held by GrubHub; provisional 17 June 2014, filed 17 June 2015, granted 17 December 2019). It discloses a stored-value gift token created for a recipient, purchaser-set restrictions on redemption down to item and SKU level, and a request that the stored value be redeemable by a third user as well as the named one. It is named for what it discloses — item-specific gift tokens and a recipient other than the one first named — and, like every live family in this section, **nothing here is a reading of its claims.** The adjacent families are named so that a reader with better search starts where we stopped.

2.5 · The direct tier: the code is a live commercial category, and only the type survives

The first survey reached the instrument's charitable relatives and missed its commercial siblings. A second survey, on 2026-09-05, asked the narrower question a merchant would ask — *who already sells a gift code for one specific item, redeemed at a local counter?* — and the answer is that the category is shipping. **Its evidence class is lower than the first survey's**: about ten queries through a US-region index and a reading of three competitors' published terms, not pre-registered.

	legal form	expiry	unredeemed value	pass it on?
spot (terms eff. 2026-08-24)	merchant gift card / stored-value pass	none imposed once issued; no dormancy or inactivity fees	remains claimable; no automatic refund for an unclaimed gift	not addressed; first eligible claimant is the recipient
OneOnMe	non-reloadable virtual prepaid card, bank-issued	none stated; $2.50/month fee after 12 months of inactivity	balance persists	not addressed
Klink-iT (terms upd. 2024-01-30)	fees earned and collected only at redemption	7 days from purchase	full amount refunded to the sender	"NON-TRANSFERABLE, NOT FOR RESALE"
THIS INSTRUMENT	an item claim (§3.1, never an amount)	intermediary: a window; recipient: none but the merchant's existence	lapses to the merchant as recognised revenue (§7, §7.2); no forward view (§7.1)	the relayed state CANNOT redeem; passing is its only operation

What it does to the claims, in order of damage.

The item-level gift code is not this paper's. Picking a real menu item for someone and having them redeem it at the counter is a commercial product today, in at least three legal shapes — a merchant stored-value pass, a bank-issued prepaid card wearing an item's face, and an order paid only at redemption with no stored value at all. Nothing in §3 should be read as claiming the code.

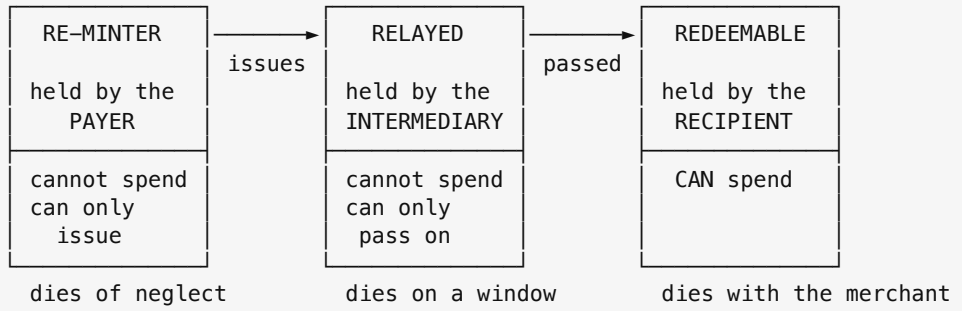
The no-clock half of claims 8 and 10 is attested. One of the three states, in its current terms, that once a gift is issued it carries no expiration dates and no dormancy or inactivity fees, and that an unclaimed gift remains claimable. *A gift that never expires by the platform's clock* is therefore not claimed here. What remains is the **pair**: no rendered time at any state, and a redeemable claim bounded only by the merchant's continued existence, disclosed at receipt, with no forward view of pending lapses given to the merchant (claims 8, 10, 12 together).

Claim 1 survives, and against better evidence than silence. None of the three has a state in which the holder can only pass the gift on. One of them considered transferability and **forbade it in capitals** — its products are non-transferable and not for resale, and an unredeemed gift is refunded to the sender after seven days. That is the same axis as §6, decided the other way. A competitor who chose the inverse property is stronger evidence that the property is a choice, and unoccupied, than an absence of results would be.

One incidental finding cuts toward §7's argument rather than toward any claim. The bank-issued form carries a monthly maintenance fee after twelve months of inactivity — a charge that runs against the holder of a gift while nothing happens. It is the attested form of the clock §7 forbids on the redeemable state.

3 · The instrument, specified

The instrument has three states. It is one object moving through them, not three products.



State 1 — the re-minter. The payer buys a claim on a specific good from a specific merchant and receives an instrument that **cannot be redeemed by anyone, including the payer**. Its only operation is *issue to an intermediary*.

State 2 — relayed. The intermediary holds a claim they cannot spend. Its only operation is *pass to a recipient*. **There is no redeem operation on this state. Not a disabled one — an absent one.** §6 argues that this distinction is the whole mechanism.

State 3 — redeemable. The recipient holds an ordinary claim on the good and may present it to the merchant. The relay is over.

Across the three states, *held by* is custody and *addressed to* is ownership in §7's sense: the payer and the intermediary hold without being addressees, and the recipient is the first party to whom the instrument has been given as a gift.

Three further properties hold across the states.

The chain travels with the instrument. Every state carries `from` (who paid) and, once issued, `via` (who chose the recipient). The recipient sees both roles even when a name is withheld.

Anonymity is a property of the instrument, not of a relationship. A payer may withhold their name. When they do, **the name is withheld from everyone — intermediary and recipient alike — and the chain is withheld from no one.** It is never partially lifted, and the *fact of the chain* is never suppressed: the recipient is told that someone asked the intermediary to pass this on. **Thanking a person you have not been told exists is not thanks; it is routing.**

Every link is thankable, including an anonymous one. A thank addressed to a withheld payer reaches them without their name travelling back. This is not a courtesy feature; §4 argues it is load-bearing, because an anonymity that also severed the possibility of gratitude would be indistinguishable from an absence.

3.1 · The data model

The instrument is one record. Its state is derived from which fields are populated, not stored as a separate flag that could disagree with them.

```
relay {
  id              opaque, high-entropy, rate-limited on lookup
  merchant        the shop the claim is against
  item            a SPECIFIC good — never a monetary amount
  paid_at         when the claim was purchased

  from            the payer's account
  from_anonymous  bool — withholds the NAME, never the chain
  via             the intermediary's account   (null until issued)
  to              the recipient's account      (null until passed)

  issued_at       payer → intermediary
  passed_at       intermediary → recipient
  redeemed_at     recipient → merchant
  lapsed_at       a window closed with no pass
  lapses[]        { at }   — every closed window, so a re-issue has a history

  thanks[]        { by, to_role: from|via, at }   — role, not identity
}
```

Three details in this schema are doing doctrinal work and would be easy to get wrong.

`item`**, never** `amount`**.** The claim is on one specific good. A field holding a monetary value would make this a stored-value instrument, which changes its legal character, its accounting treatment, and its relationship to the merchant — and would reintroduce every incentive the design removes. **The distinction is a schema decision, not a policy one.**

`thanks[].to_role`**, never** `to_identity`**.** A thank is addressed to a *role in the chain* — the one who paid, the one who chose you — and is resolved to a person only at delivery. **This is what lets an anonymous payer be thanked without their name existing anywhere the recipient can reach.** A schema that addressed thanks to identities would have to either leak the name or drop the thank. `to_role` resolves inside the platform to the account that currently holds the role; delivery is to that account, and the identity never appears in the message or to the sender.

> **Current form.** The route just described resolves *inside the platform*: the platform keeps, for every anonymous giver, a pointer from the role to an account, so it knows who the giver is and only declines to say. The institution's shop software now implements a second route that does not read such a pointer (§3.4, claim 15): the note is written on the instrument and read with a secret the giver's phone already holds. The platform-side resolution above is retained as a disclosed variant, and §3.4 states what the second route costs.

No `standing`**, no** `credit`**, no** `generosity_score`**.** §4 argues that nothing is transferred to the intermediary. **The absence of a field is how that argument is enforced.** There is no quantity to account for, dispute, audit, or eventually rank.

3.2 · A worked relay, end to end

An adult in another country, a fourteen-year-old, and a small coffee shop near the fourteen-year-old's school.

1. **The payer buys one iced coffee** from the shop and directs it to the fourteen-year-old, with the payer's own name withheld. A record exists with `from` set, `from_anonymous` true, `via` and `to` null. **The payer**

cannot drink it. The instrument the payer holds has no redeem operation; his only available action is to issue.

2. **The payer issues it to the fourteen-year-old.** `via` is set, `issued_at` stamped. The fourteen-year-old's view reads: *someone asked you to pass this on — one iced coffee, at the coffee shop by your school.* **The fourteen-year-old is told the chain exists and not who is in it.** He is not told that a gift is being kept from him; he is told he has been given something to give.
3. **The fourteen-year-old passes it to a classmate.** He chooses; nobody suggests. `to` is set, `passed_at` stamped, and the instrument's state changes: **the classmate holds an ordinary redeemable claim.** From this moment nothing in the design may expire it except the shop closing.
4. **The classmate redeems it** at the counter. The shop serves a coffee it was paid for at step 1.
5. **The classmate thanks.** Two links are offered: *the person who handed it to you* and *the person who paid for it*. She thanks both. The fourteen-year-old receives a thank addressed to him by name. **The payer receives a thank addressed to a role the payer occupies, carrying no obligation and returning no name.**

Notice what the classmate's gratitude does at step 5, and how little of it is the instrument's doing. She is grateful to the fourteen-year-old because he handed her a coffee. Nothing was transferred to him to make that happen; the payer's name was simply not there for her gratitude to land on. **The mechanism's entire contribution is an absence, held open long enough for her own attribution to fill it.**

And notice what does not happen. Nobody is paid. The shop is not paid extra for hosting a relay; the fourteen-year-old is not paid for passing it on; the payer receives nothing but a thank the payer cannot spend. **The instrument moves one coffee and no money beyond the first purchase.**

3.3 · An institutional payer

The payer in §3.2 is a person. The same instrument can be issued by a fund that is not one — in this institution, the Aquarian Pool℠, a common fund administered under published rules — and the substitution changes four things. It is specified here at the width of a claim (claim 13) and no further, because it is designed and not built.

The anonymity stops being a choice and becomes a property. A person may withhold their name; a fund operating under rules has none to offer. Its instruments carry `from_anonymous` without exception, and what an intermediary, a recipient or a merchant sees is **indistinguishable from an instrument issued by an anonymous individual** — the same record, the same wording, no funded-by label to suppress. §4's inversion reaches its limit case: the payer's absence is total, so the standing that forms in the recipient can only land on the intermediary. The indistinguishability must hold at every layer that carries the payment, not only on the screen: a credit that reaches the merchant's owner by a path only the fund uses identifies the fund as surely as a name would.

Selection is a draw, not a judgment. A fund that chose which merchant and which intermediary would be allocating custom and standing by preference. Instead both are drawn over committed rosters by a publicly recomputable procedure; where a published order would itself identify which anonymous instruments were

the fund's, the order is sealed during the season and revealed to named verifiers at its end. That procedure is specified in *Decided by No One*, which treats this surface as its sealed regime; this paper claims only that the relay's payer may be seated that way.

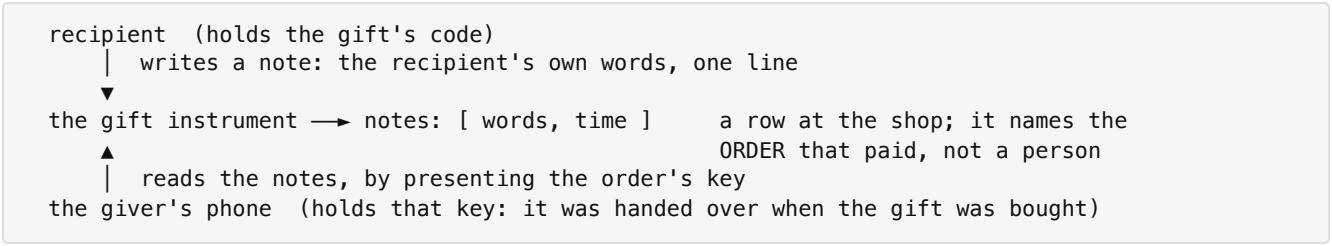
The merchant gives, and is thanked rather than paid. The fund never buys the good. A merchant whose owner has consented to be in the roster gives it, and the owner is credited at the posted price — the price an individual would have paid, so that the fund's instruments cannot be told apart by amount — in capacity that can only be given onward and is emptied at a periodic reset like every such fund. **This is not a chain in which no link ever holds liquid value.** The owner's onward gift from that capacity lands, one hop later, in someone else's ordinary account, where it is spendable; the chain of *this* instrument — fund, intermediary, recipient, merchant — carries no liquid value, and the next gift is another instrument.

The relay does not die of neglect; it is re-addressed. For a person, §7's re-minter ends when the payer stops issuing. A fund does not forget, so a lapsed instrument is re-addressed to a **new** intermediary, drawn as the first was, until it is redeemed or the merchant closes. It is never re-addressed to an intermediary whose window has already closed on it: sending it back to someone who let it lapse would be a reminder of an omission, and the lapsed intermediary is told nothing. Two consequences follow. The fund's continued re-addressing is exactly the activity on which claim 9 rests, so the instrument is never dormant. And the lapse settlement of claim 11 does not arise for these instruments, because the claim does not lapse to anyone; the price is an outstanding inventory of claims at each merchant with no clock on it, bounded by the number the owner has agreed to hold and settling only because each re-address reaches someone new.

What the census found, and what survives. A pre-registered survey on 2026-09-06 (eight queries) attested every leg separately. **A rule-bound payer choosing recipients by lot is ordinary**: in October 2020 the People's Bank of China and the Shenzhen municipal government gave 50,000 randomly selected residents 200 digital yuan each, spendable at 3,389 designated outlets between 12 and 18 October. It is the most useful **contrast** in the survey, because it is the same issuer-and-lottery shape carrying three properties this instrument refuses: the payer was known and announced, the merchants were paid in money, and the value was bounded by a one-week window. A second public-payer contrast has a different shape: a means-tested food benefit (§6.1), which also has a known payer and pays merchants in money, but names its recipients by eligibility and puts its restriction on a spendable balance. **Give-only value is also ordinary**: charity gift cards, sold since 2007 and marketed for client and employee gifts, are spent only by choosing a registered charity to receive them. That is the **near-miss** — give-only, but restricted to charities, where the capacity here may be given to any person. The survivor is the composition of claim 13 and nothing wider: *an anonymous-by-construction fund, drawing merchant and intermediary, thanking the merchant's owner in give-only capacity, and re-addressing on lapse.* **What survives is a composition, and a fund being the payer changes the actor, never the mechanism.**

3.4 · A second route for the thanks: the giver's own copy of the code

Claim 4's route needs the platform to remember who the giver is. A thank addressed to a role is resolved to "the account that currently holds the role," which means a record linking role to account exists for as long as the thank can be sent. This section discloses a second route that leaves the pointer out of the route itself, and it widens the scope while it does so: from a relay chain to **any anonymous item gift**, a direct gift being a chain of one link. It is a disclosed alternative beside claim 4's route, not a replacement for it.



How it works. The instrument carries a server-side field naming the order that paid for it, and a re-mint carries the field onward. The order holds the hash of a key that the giver's phone received at purchase. To read, the phone presents the key; the server checks it against the hash and returns the notes of the gifts that order made. At no step does the read ask who the caller is. A note is plain text of at most 140 characters; the write operation has no field for an amount or a token of value, and a gift carries at most twenty notes so that a code cannot become a way to buzz a phone. A gift paid for by a fund has no order and therefore no route; its notes rest on the instrument and are read by no one. The giver may separately ask to be told when a note arrives, which stores a pointer to that giver's device against that order; the notice carries no words, and this opt-in pointer is the one place the route holds an identifier at all, put there by the giver's choice.

What the route does not do, stated before anyone relies on it.

1. **Custody is a precondition.** The route lives in possession of the key. A lost phone ends it. It also reaches *whoever holds the key*, which is the giver only so long as the phone stays the giver's.
2. **The giver cannot verify it, by design.** If no note arrives, the giver cannot tell a lost route from a recipient who read the door and declined, or never saw it. That indistinguishability is a property the design keeps on purpose, since a recipient who owes nothing cannot be made to owe by it. It follows that the route must never be described as a *guarantee* to the giver: what can be said is that a note, if one is written, is retrievable by the holder of the key for as long as the key and the shop's row both survive.
3. **The note is as durable as the shop's row.** It lives on a shop-side record. If the row is deleted or the shop closes, the note goes with it.
4. "**No record consulted**" **describes the route, not the platform.** The instrument's order field exists. For a signed-in customer the order may carry a customer identifier, and the optional notice stores a device pointer. A person with access to the database could join these. What is claimed is that the route does not read them. The anonymity this buys is anonymity against the recipient and against the surfaces the platform draws, not against inference: at one small shop the owner who released the gift after checking the payment knows who paid, and in a family a single likely giver is easy to guess.

Each guard, called what it is. The route ships with surface rules, and they are not all of one kind:

guard	how the build holds it	what it is
words only; nothing of value travels back	the write takes text; there is no amount field	a property of the operation's type
nothing returned names or describes the payer; the answer is the same whether a person or a fund paid	the reply carries the item, the words and the time	a property of the reply's shape
a note carries no claim index, no state, and not which door it was written from	the record is words and time; a note may be written before, after or without use of the gift	a property of the record's shape
the giver is shown no absence: no count of thanked against sent, no row reading "no reply"	the server returns no row for a gift with no note	a property of the reply on the server; the giver's phone knows what it bought and could draw the difference, so the last step is a **rule on the client**
the recipient is never prompted to thank	no code path sends the recipient anything; the door is a quiet link	an **absence of code**, held by review, so a rule in §6's sense
the channel must not make the giver a creditor	a design aim served by the guards above	neither: nothing enforces it except the others

Whether the bundle may be called a property of the object, as the paper calls claim 1's missing operation, is left open; this section says only what each guard is, and the last two fail the remove-the-enforcer test of §6: take away the reviewer and the client's good behavior, and nothing holds them.

The purpose, and its honest limit. The return channel exists so that a giver who gave anonymously can *witness* what the gift did, which is a different thing from being thanked: a giver who can see an effect has a reason to give again, so anonymous giving would otherwise compete at a disadvantage against visible giving. The limit is the one §2.4 already names. The Dānamahapphala Sutta (AN 7.52 in the CST numbering) opens its list of motives with the one who gives *sāpekho*, with an eye to a return (`s0403m3.mul.xml:1392`, mūla), and gives that giver the first destination of its list, among the Cātumahārājika devas (`:1396`). A channel back can admit the waiting. The design can protect the *recipient* from pressure, since nothing is owed and nothing renders its absence; it cannot purify the giver's intention, and no sentence here should be read as saying it does.

What was found, and what survives. A quick census on 2026-09-29 (pre-registered, nine queries, two patent pages and one blog opened) found every mechanism in the commons. Fundraising guidance tells organizations to pass thanks for an anonymous donor to the intermediary who forwards it, which was the control the census had to see. WO 2003/077164 A1 (*Anonymous gifting*, RSVP Personals International Ltd, priority 13 March 2002; listed as ceased, which the source marks as an assumption) shows a recipient only the donor's alias and tells the donor that the recipient receives a stamp "so he/she can thank you personally." WO 2011/014869 A2 (*Method and system for giving a gift*, GIIV Inc, priority 31 July 2009; also listed as ceased on the same footing) states that a purchase of a gift code "may also result in a 'thank you' message by the gift recipient via mobile, e-mail or social network." Bearer-secret return channels for anonymous parties

are older than either gift filing: a source using SecureDrop can "return to receive follow-up correspondence" (SecureDrop documentation), and anonymous tip lines issue a tip number and password for the same purpose. Claim 4 of this paper already discloses the role-addressed form. These are named for what they disclose, and nothing here is a reading of any claim of any of them. **What the census did not find, in that aperture on that date, is the composition of claim 15:** an item gift at an ordinary shop whose anonymous giver reads the recipient's note with the giver's own copy of the code, the route consulting no record of the giver's identity, no prompt sent to the recipient. The remaining clause, that the giver-facing surface never shows an unthanked gift as unthanked, was not searched, and the survivor is provisional by exactly that much.

What is untested. The route is built; no result is reported here, and whether a return channel changes how often anonymous givers give again is an open prediction that this paper does not register or answer. The route to a *re-giver* and any transfer of Kiitos with a note are not built.

4 · The inversion: anonymity that confers rather than protects

This is the paper's narrow claim, and it should be read at exactly this width.

In every use of anonymity the census found — philanthropic, commercial, religious, folk — **the anonymity is protective, and the person it protects is the giver.** They may wish to avoid solicitation, or publicity, or the social weight that a known gift imposes on a recipient; classical treatments of anonymous giving are organised almost entirely around the giver's motive and the recipient's dignity. Anonymity is a shield the giver holds in front of themselves.

Here it does the opposite work. **The payer withholds their name so that the intermediary is the one who appears generous.** The fourteen-year-old hands a friend a coffee; the friend's gratitude has nowhere to land but on him. The payer's absence is not self-protection — it is the mechanism by which the fourteen-year-old acquires standing he did not have.

It is worth being precise about what does and does not happen, because the natural description of this is wrong in a way that matters.

Nothing is transferred to the intermediary. The payer does not hand over credit, or reputation, or merit; there is no such quantity moving between them. What happens is that **the payer's name is absent**, and the recipient's own act of attribution — their own gratitude, forming in them, directed at the person in front of them — does the work. The absence is the condition. Nothing crosses.

This is not a fastidious distinction. A mechanism described as *transferring credit* invites a ledger of credit, and a ledger of credit invites the accounting that this instrument exists to avoid: how much was transferred, whether it was enough, whether it can be reclaimed. **Described correctly, there is no quantity to account for.** The design implication is direct: there is no field in the schema for standing, no measure of how generous the intermediary appeared, and nothing anyone can audit or dispute.

The inversion has an ancient folk precedent, and the paper's claim must be stated against it rather than around it. A parent hands a child a coin to put in the collection plate so that the child is the one who gives. This is widespread, undated, and performs exactly the move described above. **The claim is therefore**

not that nobody has done this. It is that no ledger doing it was found in the apertures of §2 — that the move, as far as those searches reach, has lived in the space between two people who know each other, and was not found given an instrument that can carry it between strangers, preserve who was involved, and let gratitude reach a person whose name was never said.

The contribution class is accordingly **instrumentation and cross-domain transposition**, not discovery. That is a defensible class and a modest one, and it is the class the census supports.

5 · Why no link may be paid

The unpaid constraint reads like an ethical flourish. It is the load-bearing engineering constraint in the paper, and there are three arguments for it in increasing order of force.

The doctrinal argument. A relay that paid its intermediary would be a referral programme, and the value moving to the intermediary would be compensation for propagation rather than a gift. The instrument's whole content is that the intermediary *received the giving*; paying them converts what they received into a job. This argument is sound and is the weakest of the three, because it is available only to a reader who already accepts the frame.

The structural argument. Nearly every chain-attribution system in commerce exists in order to pay someone — that is what the attribution is *for*; the exceptions track for analytics. The moment a payment attaches to a link, the chain acquires an optimisation target, and the behaviour that follows is well documented in the multi-level marketing literature (Keep & Vander Nat 2014): recruitment displaces the ostensible purpose, because recruitment is what pays. **An unpaid chain has no upline to enrich and therefore no gradient to climb.** The chain here exists to be *seen*, not to be *settled*, and nothing in it is a claim on anyone.

The empirical argument, which is the strongest and is not the authors'. The developmental literature reports that **children offered a reward for performing a kind act are less likely to repeat it** — the overjustification effect, in which an extrinsic incentive displaces the intrinsic motivation it was meant to reinforce (Warneken & Tomasello 2008; Fabes et al. 1989). The intermediary in the founding case is fourteen years old, and the evidence is from young children; the gap is stated in §9. **A relay that paid him would not merely be doctrinally impure; the literature predicts it would reduce the behaviour it exists to produce.**

The three arguments converge, and the convergence is the finding worth carrying: the purity condition and the engineering condition are the same condition. A designer who cared nothing for the doctrine and only for whether the mechanism works would arrive at the same constraint by reading the psychology. That is a coincidence of goods rather than a trade-off between them, and it is the reason the constraint can be stated absolutely rather than balanced against growth.

One honest consequence. The instrument is a referral mechanism that pays no referral fee, which means its growth is bounded by how much people want to give rather than by how much they can earn. **This is slower, and the paper does not claim otherwise.**

6 · Type, not rule: why the non-redeemability must be structural

The intermediary must not be able to spend the claim. There are two ways to arrange this and they are not equivalent.

As a rule: the intermediary *may* redeem but is asked not to. The instrument carries an instruction, perhaps a reminder, perhaps a social expectation. Compliance depends on the intermediary being the sort of person who complies at the moment of temptation.

As a type: the instrument in the relayed state **has no redeem operation**. Not a disabled button, not a permission check that could be misconfigured — the operation does not exist on that state.

Apply the diagnostic this institution applies to every guard: **remove the enforcer.** Under the rule, the enforcer is the intermediary's character, and it must be present at the exact moment it is tested — which is the moment nobody can guarantee. Under the type, there is no enforcer, because there is nothing to comply with.

The difference is not fastidiousness about implementation. It determines whether the census verdict holds. **If the intermediary can redeem, then their passing it on is inspiration — a downstream effect, hoped-for, no part of what was given — and the attested pattern in §2.2 covers the instrument entirely — which is exactly what F2 tests.** The literature is full of anonymous gifts that inspired their recipients to become givers. It contains nothing the authors could find in which the giving *is the content of the gift*. That difference is a single line of code, and it is the whole claim.

It follows that a redeem path added later "for edge cases" does not degrade the instrument gracefully. **It converts it into a different and unremarkable one.** This should be stated in any implementation's own documentation, because the pressure to add such a path will be real: intermediaries will lapse, and someone will propose letting them keep it.

The pressure has a second shape, and it arrives disguised as a different feature. Suppose the merchant later lets a holder hand a claim back in exchange for credit on an account with the shop — a tab, store credit, a balance. For the recipient that is a harmless convenience. On the relayed state it is a redeem path under another name: the intermediary taking the value onto their own account is exactly the consumption the type forbids. **So conversion is not a separate capability to be permitted or withheld state by state; it is the same capability as redemption and lives exactly where redemption lives.** A state with no redeem operation has no conversion operation to add, and a single exception — convert yes, redeem no — would be a third combination that turns the type back into a rule.

> **Current form.** The conversion this paragraph supposes is now part of the design as specified: a holder of a redeemable claim may hand it back for credit on an account with the merchant, struck at what the item is worth on that day and never less than the payer paid, so that a claim with no clock cannot lose value silently. Conversion exists exactly where redemption exists — on the redeemable state — and on neither the payer's instrument nor the relayed state. The paragraph above is retained as disclosed.

The type argument reaches a second object, and there it does not even need a prohibition. A merchant may publish an **invitation**: a place and an hour it chose — a table, a cart, a boat, at a time — offered to people it does not yet know. Nobody buys it. That single fact settles its relation to money. A claim that was

purchased carries a price, and converting it into credit strikes at that price; an invitation carries no purchase price, so a conversion would have nothing to strike at and would issue money-denominated credit that arose from no exchange. The obvious design would forbid the conversion. **The invitation needs no such rule, because the field a conversion reads does not exist on it — conversion is *undefined* by the type, not *forbidden* by a clause.** It is the move of §6 applied to a different object: take the property from the object, and the enforcer has nothing left to enforce.

The census for this object (2026-09-18, pre-registered) killed the loose reading and narrowed the strict one. A venue publishing a standing, non-convertible invitation is attested: the Chatty Café Scheme, begun in Oldham, England, in 2017, marks tables at which talking to strangers is explicitly welcome, and a national coffee chain rolled such tables out to some 300 stores in 2018. **The two halves of the strict reading are public separately.** Prepaid restaurant reservations bind a place to a time, and are transferable: on at least one platform a guest may "*gift or sell their booking for any amount up to the original purchase price*", so the booking carries a price that a transfer can realise. Suspended coffee binds a good to a place, carries no time, and is kept from being turned into anything else by the café's practice rather than by the object. What was not found, in that aperture on that date, is the **pair** — a place-and-hour invitation that is non-convertible *by construction* — and that is claim 14's full width. Full-text patent classification search did not run for this census, and nothing outside the English-language, US-region index was searched.

A cost must be recorded against this choice. An instrument the intermediary cannot use may be experienced as a chore rather than a gift — a task with a deadline. The authors' answer is that the intermediary's agency lives in the *addressing* rather than the *consuming*: they choose freely who receives it, and that choice is the substance of what they were given. Whether recipients experience it that way is an empirical question with n=0, and §9 records it as such.

6.1 · Given, not spent: a purpose restriction as a type, and where it stops

§6 makes its argument about two operations, redemption and conversion. A third object shows the same move: a **purpose restriction** on a benefit, such as *food only* or *this neighborhood only*. Value can carry such a restriction in two different ways, and they are not equivalent.

On value that is spent, the restriction is a rule on a balance. The U.S. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) is an entitlement paid to eligible households as a balance on a card, spendable at authorized retailers on eligible foods. The restriction is policed by authorization of the retailer and penalties on the people who break it, and it can be broken from either end: the Congressional Research Service defines trafficking as "the illicit sale of SNAP benefits, which can involve both retailers and recipients." The Food and Nutrition Service estimates the national retailer trafficking rate at 1.50% of benefits redeemed for FY2012–FY2014 and 1.60% for FY2015–FY2017 (CRS IF10860, Table 2). That is a share of benefits trafficked, not a price. A price appears only as an illustration, in the Inspector General's 2010 testimony: retailers "might exchange $50 in cash for $100 in benefits." The restriction mostly holds. Its leak is as large as the balance a seller will take for cash, and it is closed only by a seller's compliance, which is why it is a rule.

On value that is given, the same restriction can be a type. A claim on a named item at a named shop (§3.1: `item`, never `amount`) is redeemed at that shop's counter. Place follows from the shop without any

radio or location check, since redemption happens where the shop is. The platform offers no cash-out of the claim: the operations on it are look up, pass on (the relayed state only), redeem at the counter, hand back for the shop's own credit (the *Current form* note in §6), and re-mint a lapsed one, and none of them yields money. The restriction therefore does not depend on a vendor policing a balance, because the unconverted claim is not a balance anyone can sell through the platform. The value goes through the shop as the thing itself, and the shop is thanked for giving it.

What is typed is an item at a named shop, not "food." Food follows from what the shop sells, and the institution's intent that its in-kind giving be food is carried by which shops are on its rosters, not by the claim. A shop that sells tools hands over tools. The section describes a food claim as the gift of a thing; it does not describe it as a device so that a person cannot waste money, and a reader should not take it that way.

Where the type stops. Four limits, each stated before anyone relies on the contrast.

1. **A shop and a recipient can settle by hand.** A recipient can hand the code over, or just the right to it, for cash at the counter. The platform has no operation for that and no sight of it. This is the true analog of retailer trafficking, and it is not prevented by anything in the instrument. The shop already holds the giver's payment, so such a deal leaves the shop better off than honoring the claim when the cash it pays is below its own cost of the goods, and worse off when it is above. The figure decides, and the authors have not measured it; the barrier is an incentive, not a type.
2. **The code is a bearer string.** A recipient can sell it or give it to anyone, and the instrument cannot tell.
3. **A converted claim is a balance.** The conversion described in §6's *Current form* note turns a redeemable claim into credit with the shop, held by the recipient. The sentence *nobody holds a balance to sell* is true of the **unconverted** claim only. Whether holding that credit reopens the leak this section argues against is an open question: it sets this section against the conversion design, and the institution has not ruled between them.
4. **Remove the enforcer.** For the platform, the restriction survives the test: there is nothing to police because no operation exists. For the shop and recipient together it fails: the enforcer is the shop's honesty, and the only cost to cashing out by hand is the shop's own loss, which is an incentive.

SNAP is a contrast, not a predecessor. SNAP is an entitlement: it seats the eligible as recipients and guarantees them a benefit. A gift is guaranteed to no one. Nothing here is offered in place of a public benefit, and the section claims no advantage over one. A separate design of the institution gives every verified person a floor of the capacity to give food, in kind; it is described in `manufactured-universal-giving`, not here.

Prior art. The humanitarian sector has its own name for the split. The CaLP glossary defines a *commodity voucher* as one redeemable at participating vendors for goods or services chosen from a pre-determined list, and says such vouchers are typically significantly more restricted than *value vouchers*. Grocery vouchers bought abroad for relatives at home are an ordinary diaspora service; the 2026-10-01 census recorded Musi/Saimart in Zimbabwe and Puregold's #PurePadala (2015) as instances. The type-versus-rule split is therefore the sector's, and the contribution of this section is only its application to a gift and to a relay. It makes no claim and asserts no priority.

7 · The lifecycle, and the one rule that generates it

Each of the three states ends differently, and the differences are generated by a single rule rather than by three policies.

> **A clock runs while the instrument has no addressee — no one to whom it has been given as a gift. It stops the moment it does.**

Held by is custody; *addressed to* is ownership in the rule's sense. The payer and the intermediary hold the instrument without being its addressees — the payer bought it to give, the intermediary was given it to give on — and the recipient, to whom it was given as a gift, is its first addressee.

The re-minter dies of neglect. If an issued instrument lapses and the payer does not issue again within a re-issue window — a deployment parameter, one cycle by default — the whole thing ends. This has an unobvious consequence in its favour: unclaimed-property regimes key on *dormancy*, and an instrument its holder touches on a recurring cycle is never dormant. The mechanism therefore does not bound the escheat exposure — it prevents it from arising. And an instrument that lives only while someone is actively trying to place a gift is honest about mortality: it dies with a payer who dies, forgets, or loses access, within one window.

The relayed state dies on a window. An unaddressed occasion held indefinitely is a hoarded occasion. The window is what prevents accumulation, and it is the same instrument the institution uses on its other transient vessels.

The redeemable state dies with the merchant. This is not a clock. Nothing ticks, nothing is displayed, and the holder is never told they are running out of time. It is a dependency on the counterparty existing, which is how every merchant obligation is bounded: a claim on one coffee from a particular shop is worth nothing once that shop closes. **The instrument does not expire because anyone decided it should; it expires because the thing it claims no longer exists.**

The resulting asymmetry — the intermediary's instrument expires and the recipient's does not — looks like an inconsistency and is not. The rule is symmetric; the *states* differ. An unaddressed instrument belongs to nobody and is coerced to move; an addressed one is somebody's, and nothing in the design may end it. This distinction is older than the instrument: it is the same line the institution draws between transient communal vessels, which it forces to empty, and personal accounts, which it never touches.

Two constraints follow and are stated as constraints rather than as preferences. First, **remaining time is never rendered**, at any state: a terminal date exists to be reached, not displayed, and a countdown on a gift is a pressure applied to a person who was given something. Second, **an expiry on the redeemable state is forbidden** — that would be a clock imposed on a recipient holding a kindness, which is the one place the design will not bend. A merchant obligation that must terminate should terminate structurally, by the merchant's own closure, not by a timer aimed at the person holding the claim.

Disclosure rather than process. Because the redeemable claim depends on the merchant existing, the holder is told so once, at the moment of receipt, in the instrument's own text — *good for one coffee at this shop, for as long as this shop is open.* **This is not a caveat but a specification of what the thing is:** a claim on a real place run by real people, whose life is that place's life. It is materially different from corporate

scrip, and saying so at receipt costs nothing, whereas discovering it at a closed counter costs everything the instrument was for.

7.1 · What the merchant sees, and the one thing they must not

The merchant's position in a relay is unusual: they are paid at step 1, they perform at step 4, and **they have no visibility into and no influence over steps 2 and 3.** The intermediary is not their customer. The recipient is a stranger until they arrive.

They see: relays purchased against their shop, relays redeemed, and — after the fact — relays that lapsed and whose deferred revenue has been recognised. That last is an ordinary accounting entry and there is no reason to hide it.

What they must not see is a forward view: no list of outstanding relays, no forecast of what is about to lapse, no breakage projection, and no control that would let them influence whether a relay completes. The reasoning is not that merchants are untrustworthy. It is that **an incentive with no handle cannot be acted on**, and the cheapest way to guarantee no handle exists is to withhold the number rather than to trust restraint about it. Concretely, the merchant's surface exposes purchased, redeemed, and lapsed-and-recognised records only; there is no query over outstanding instruments, so the forward view is not withheld by policy — it does not exist on the surface.

At one shop this is close to redundant — the merchant genuinely cannot reach an intermediary they have never met. At platform scale it is not: a larger operator hosting many merchants will eventually host one with levers, and the guard is written for that case rather than for the founding one: it exists because the lapse-revenue incentive is real at platform scale (§9). *A number nobody was shown cannot be optimised, which is a weaker claim than a number that does not exist, and the authors would prefer the stronger one if they could find it.*

7.2 · Three designs for unredeemed value, and the road not taken

Every gift instrument must say what happens to value that is never collected. The direct tier (§2.5) shows three answers in live use, and they create three different incentives.

design	who	what it makes someone want
BREAKAGE — value forfeits to issuer or merchant	the gift-card industry; a no-refund gift code	the issuer or merchant profits when the gift fails
SENDER-REFUND on a short clock	a gift app: 7 days, then the full amount refunded	honest with the money — but a clock runs on the recipient
COUNTERPARTY-DISSOLUTION, no clock, no forward view	this instrument (§7): a recipient's claim ends only with the merchant	the merchant benefits when a relay is never placed, and is shown no gradient (§7.1, §9)

The first road is the one §9 argues this instrument's lapse settlement is not, while conceding that it leaves the merchant a similar incentive; §7.1 is the mitigation. The third is this paper's. **The second deserves an answer, because it is the one a reader sympathetic to the design would propose:** return the money to the payer, recognise nothing, and the merchant never benefits from a failure.

It is not taken, for two reasons, and the second is the stronger. First, a refund on a short window is a clock on a person holding a kindness — the exact thing §7 forbids on the redeemable state — and a week is short enough to work as pressure however it is worded. Second, **a refundable gift has not been given.** If lapse returns the value to the payer, then what the payer bought was a deposit held on the recipient's behalf, revocable by time, and the gift was never the recipient's. It is the same invariant that makes the re-minter's re-issued instrument a relayed one rather than a redeemable one: a payer who could get the value back, by consuming or by refund, turns the instrument into a refundable deposit. The instrument therefore keeps the one road on which the value, once given, never returns to the giver — and accepts, in §9, the incentive that road leaves the merchant.

8 · Why the chain is bounded at two

The relay is bounded: an intermediary passes to a recipient, and the recipient may redeem. They cannot pass another relayed instrument onward.

This is a real limitation and the paper does not disguise it as a virtue. An unbounded version — each recipient becoming the next intermediary — is closer to the pay-it-forward ideal and would produce a longer chain. It also produces an instrument that **nobody may ever consume**: a hot potato whose terminal state never arrives, and a gift that cannot be received has stopped being one. Bounding it at two is the shortest length at which the mechanism's actual content — *making someone a giver* — is delivered at all.

The consequence for the surrounding theory is that **this instrument is not the unbounded forward-chain**, and any paper that describes it as such has borrowed a property it does not have. Unbounded circulation exists elsewhere in the architecture, in instruments whose forward-spendability has no depth limit. This one is a short relay with a designed terminus, and it should be classified as one.

9 · Honest limitations and open questions

The censuses are desk surveys. Six of them, tabulated in the Prior-Art and Non-Assertion Statement: marketing copy, published terms, secondary literature and web-indexed patents, through a US-region index. None is fieldwork and none is exhaustive; one was not pre-registered; full-text patent classification search did not run for the last, and no survey is recorded as having searched outside English — including the language of the market the instrument is built for. Every census on this instrument has returned less than the authors proposed; a reader with better search should assume each surviving composition is attested too until shown otherwise.

n = 0. No instrument described here has been operated with real participants. Every behavioural claim — that intermediaries experience the addressing as agency, that recipients find the chain meaningful rather than intrusive, that anonymity reads as generosity rather than as evasion — is untested.

The overjustification finding is borrowed and not replicated. §5's strongest argument rests on a literature the authors have read and not tested, in a population and culture different from the one the instrument is built for — the strongest studies are of children under six, and the founding intermediary is fourteen.

The founding use case satisfies the paper's own caution only partly, and the split is not where it first appeared. §2.3 reports a practitioner's observation that parent-directed generosity projects fare worse than child-led ones. An earlier version of this section called the founding case *the directed pattern the literature warns about*. That is true of one shape of the instrument and unproven of another, and it was never true of the shapes in which the child gives nothing.

An adult can put an instrument in a young person's hands in four shapes — a gift *to* them, named or anonymous, and a relay *through* them, named or anonymous:

	the adult's name shown	the adult's name withheld
a gift TO them	1 · no giving of theirs to direct → outside the warning	2 · no giving of theirs to direct → outside the warning
a relay THROUGH them	3 · "an adult I know gave me this to pass on" — a named adult assigned it → the warning applies	4 · "I have something to give, and I choose who" — no adult in the frame → the warning's mechanisms have nothing to act on

Shapes 1 and 2 are exempt for the plainest reason: the warning concerns an adult directing how a child *gives*, and a gift to the child involves no giving of the child's to direct. Shapes 3 and 4 share what the warning is about — in both, an adult decides whether an instrument exists and when, and only the addressing is the young person's — so relay-versus-gift is not the axis. **The axis is whether the direction is perceivable.** Every candidate mechanism for why directed giving underperforms — the child experiencing compliance rather than agency, the generosity being attributed to the adult, an external locus of causality — requires the child to *perceive* an adult directing. In shape 4 there is no adult to perceive. The founding case of §3.2 is shape 4.

This is a mechanistic reading, not a finding, and it must not be stated as an exemption. The observation concerns parent–child generosity projects, not anonymous instruments, and is a practitioner's rather than a study's; n = 0. And one objection survives anonymity untouched: **the task is still externally originated.** The young person did not seek it; something arrived asking them to give. What anonymity removes is the person to attribute the direction to, not the assignment. The reading is registered as a prediction in the institution's public register, **P-BG2**: sustained pass-on is higher for the anonymous relay (shape 4) than the named one (shape 3), over a window long enough for the effect to appear; its null — equal rates, or the named relay ahead — would mean the anonymity is doctrinal only, and would count against offering the named relay to minors. Shapes 1 and 2 are controls, not arms, since they contain no giving by the intermediary. The obvious further repair — letting the intermediary request instruments, or draw from a standing allowance — has not been implemented. It is recorded here rather than resolved.

The unpaid constraint is untested against growth. A mechanism that pays nobody grows only as fast as people want to give. Whether that rate is sufficient to sustain the merchants it depends on is unknown.

The institutional payer and the invitation are designs, not deployments. Neither has been built. Claim 13's anonymity by construction holds only if the fund's credits reach an owner by the same path an anonymous individual's do, which is a property of payment infrastructure not yet chosen; its draw depends on a separate specification; and its re-addressing leaves each participating merchant holding an inventory of

claims with no clock, which settles only on the expectation that a fresh intermediary eventually places each one. Claim 14 rests on a single field's absence, and a later schema that gave the invitation a price for any reason — a deposit, a no-show fee — would reintroduce the conversion it makes undefined. Both are stated here so that their failure modes are public before their first use.

The second thanks route is built and unmeasured, and it is not a guarantee. §3.4 lists its limits: custody of the key is a precondition, a lost phone ends the route, the note is as durable as the shop's row, and the giver cannot distinguish a lost route from a recipient who declined. It does not prevent inference of the giver at a small shop. Which of its guards are properties of the object and which are rules is stated guard by guard, and whether the whole bundle may be called a property is an open question. The census behind claim 15 was quick, English-only, and did not search the clause that the giver-facing surface never shows an unthanked gift. The route to a re-giver, and any transfer of Kiitos with a note, are not built. Whether a return channel changes how often anonymous givers give again is untested, and a return channel can admit the waiting that §3.4 names.

The contrast with food-restricted benefits is a contrast, not a measurement. §6.1 argues that the platform offers no cash-out operation on an unconverted claim, and it concedes that a shop and a recipient can settle by hand, that the code is a bearer string, and that a converted claim is a balance. It reports no rate of any such leak for this instrument, and the two figures it cites for SNAP are the retailer trafficking share of benefits and an Inspector General's illustration of a price, neither of them a measurement of what a recipient receives. Whether §6.1's argument is consistent with the conversion of §6's *Current form* note is unresolved.

The lifecycle's legal availability is untested. Expiration, closure as termination of the obligation, escheat, and revenue recognition on lapse all vary by jurisdiction — unclaimed-property statutes differ state by state, breakage guidance under ASC 606 has its own conditions, and some jurisdictions treat a merchant's closure as extinguishing nothing — and none of it has been tested with counsel. §7's arguments that a recurring cycle prevents dormancy from arising and that an item-denominated claim is not a stored monetary balance are plausible; **claims 8 through 11 are design positions until counsel in the jurisdiction that matters says otherwise.** §2.5 sharpens the question rather than answering it: the same product ships as a merchant stored-value pass, as a bank-issued prepaid card, and as an order paid only at redemption, and different bodies of law plausibly attach to each — the last arguably outside gift-card rules altogether. Which of these shapes this instrument is — and whether the order-paid-at-redemption shape, the one furthest from stored value, can survive a claim that lives for as long as the merchant does — is for counsel.

The lapse settlement is an accounting position, not a neutral fact. When a relay ends unclaimed, the merchant's deferred revenue is recognised. The authors argue this is not breakage — a gift card sells stored value and the issuer profits from the customer forgetting, whereas here a specific good was sold, capacity was held, and only collection lapsed, extinguished by the one party with standing to direct it. **The argument is sound and the incentive it creates is still real**: the merchant benefits when a relay fails. The mitigation specified is informational rather than motivational — **no forward view of pending lapses is exposed to the merchant**, on the reasoning that a gradient with no handle cannot be climbed. At a single shop this is adequate. At platform scale, hosting merchants who do have levers, it is a guard the authors would not want to rely on alone.

9.1 · What would falsify this, stated in advance

The authors prefer claims that can be killed. Seven are registered here, before any deployment — four at first publication, two at the 2026-09-23 revision and one at the 2026-11-03 revision.

F1 — the prior-art claim. A single attested instrument carrying all four properties *and* the inversion — anonymity used to confer standing on an intermediary, in a system that records the chain and pays no one. **One instance and §4 is withdrawn**, not narrowed.

F2 — the type-versus-rule claim. §6 asserts that permitting the intermediary to redeem collapses the instrument into the attested inspiration pattern. This is falsified if a deployment in which redemption is *permitted but discouraged* produces the same pass-on rate as one in which it is *impossible*. **That is a cheap A/B test and the authors have not run it.** If the rates match, the type/rule distinction is philosophy rather than engineering, and the paper's central mechanism is decoration on a social norm.

F3 — the unpaid claim. §5 argues that paying the intermediary would reduce the behaviour. Falsified if a paid arm shows equal or higher sustained pass-on rates over a period long enough for the overjustification effect to appear, which the literature suggests is longer than a single trial.

F4 — the substrate-cost claim inherited from §7. The lifecycle machinery is asserted to be a consequence of the gift being an object rather than a signal. Falsified if a signal-substrate givable in the same institution turns out to require comparable governance — which would mean the machinery is a property of the design's taste rather than of the substrate.

F5 — the anonymity-as-escape reading of §9. Registered publicly as P-BG2 (§9): falsified if the anonymous relay's sustained pass-on rate does not exceed the named relay's. A null would not touch claim 5, which concerns standing rather than developmental effect; it would withdraw §9's suggestion that anonymity also answers the directed-giving caution.

F6 — the type claim for the invitation (claim 14). Falsified by one attested instrument, predating this revision, that offers a place and an hour, is bought by no one, and is non-convertible because it carries no price to convert rather than because a rule forbids it. One instance and claim 14 is withdrawn.

F7 — the composition of claim 15. Falsified by one attested system that lets the anonymous giver of an item gift at an ordinary shop read the recipient's note with a secret the giver already holds, with the route consulting no record of the giver's identity, and with no prompt sent to the recipient. One instance and claim 15 is withdrawn. A finding that the clause left unsearched in §3.4 (the surface that never shows an unthanked gift) is also attested would narrow the disclosure but not the claim, which excludes it.

Note what is not on this list: whether anyone likes the instrument. Adoption failure would not falsify any claim above; it would mean the mechanism is correct and unwanted, which is a different result and should not be reported as this one.

10 · Why this matters now

Gifting is being instrumented rapidly, and many of the instruments being built are stored-value instruments with attribution attached. The economics of that design are well understood: the issuer's interest runs

toward non-redemption, the attribution exists to compensate propagation, and the resulting products optimise for recruitment because recruitment is what pays.

This paper describes a small alternative and gives it away. **Its distinguishing properties are all subtractions** — no stored value, no payment to any link, no redeem operation on the relayed state, no forward view of pending lapses, no measure of standing. What remains is an instrument whose only content is that someone who had nothing to give was placed in the position of giving, and whose only record is who was involved.

The transposition was not found in the patent literature in the apertures stated above, and the adjacent families of §2.4 are named for what they disclose. It is published here so that it stands as prior art against anyone who would later enclose it.

11 · Cross-venue references

This paper depends on and extends: *The Gift Operation* (the receive-→-give-forward atom, its six topologies, and the conserved-identity subclass this instrument instantiates); *Dual-Currency Reciprocity* (the vessels whose emptying rules §7 borrows); *The Four Elements as a Breadth-Check Discipline* (the substrate ladder from which §5's governance reasoning descends). At the 2026-09-23 revision it also depends on *Decided by No One* (the called draw, whose sealed regime seats claim 13's selection of merchant and intermediary) and *Manufactured Universal Giving* (the argument for a fund that funds people's capacity to give, which states the same composition from the fund's side; §3.3 states it from the instrument's). The first three do not cite this paper; the last two do; it assumes all five.

11.1 · Sources for the 2026-09-23 revision

Each was opened at its source on 2026-09-23 before it was cited.

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- spot, Terms of Service, effective 24 August 2026: https://usespot.me/terms
- OneOnMe, Non-Reloadable Virtual Visa Gift Card: https://oneonme.com/virtual-visa-gift-card
- Klink-iT, Terms of Service, last updated 30 January 2024: https://www.klink-it.com/terms
- Travel Bug (geocaching trackables): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Travel_Bug · https://www.geocaching.com/track/travelbugs.aspx
- Shenzhen digital-yuan red-packet lottery, October 2020: https://www.nfcw.com/2020/10/12/368565/pboc-distributes-digital-currency-to-consumers-via-red-envelope-lottery/ · https://www.ledgerinsights.com/china-central-bank-digital-currency-cbdc-ecny-giveaway-results/
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11.2 · Sources added or re-checked at the 2026-09-29 revision

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- Warneken, F. & Tomasello, M. (2008). Extrinsic rewards undermine altruistic tendencies in 20-month-olds. *Developmental Psychology*, 44(6), 1785–1788. · Fabes, R. A., Fultz, J., Eisenberg, N., May-Plumlee, T. & Christopher, F. S. (1989). Effects of rewards on children's prosocial motivation: a socialization study. *Developmental Psychology*, 25(4), 509–515. · Keep, W. W. & Vander Nat, P. J. (2014). Multilevel marketing and pyramid schemes in the United States: an historical analysis. *Journal of Historical Research in Marketing*, 6(2), 188–210. · Hyde, L. (1983). *The Gift*. New York: Random House.
- The spot, OneOnMe, Klink-iT, Travel Bug, Shenzhen, TisBest and Chatty Café sources of §11.1 were re-opened on 2026-09-29 and still state what this paper cites them for; the Tock page refused automated access that day and is cited from its 2026-09-23 reading.

11.3 · Sources added at the 2026-11-03 revision

- Congressional Research Service, *Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program: Errors and Fraud*, IF10860 (trafficking defined; Table 2, the national retailer trafficking rate, 1.50% for FY2012–FY2014 and 1.60% for FY2015–FY2017, "compared to all SNAP benefits redeemed"): https://www.congress.gov/crs_external_products/IF/PDF/IF10860/IF10860.7.pdf — opened and read in full text on 2026-11-03.
- USDA Office of Inspector General, statement of Phyllis K. Fong before the House Agriculture Subcommittee on Department Operations, Oversight, Nutrition, and Forestry, 28 July 2010 (the $50-for-$100 illustration): https://usdaoig.oversight.gov/sites/default/files/publications/2022-03/IGtestimony100728.pdf — opened and read on 2026-11-03.
- WO 2003/077164 A1, *Anonymous gifting* (RSVP Personals International Ltd): https://patents.google.com/patent/WO2003077164A1/en · WO 2011/014869 A2, *Method and system for giving a gift* (GIIV Inc): https://patents.google.com/patent/WO2011014869A2/en — both opened 2026-11-03; their ceased status is Google's assumption, not a legal conclusion, and nothing here reads their claims.

- SecureDrop, *Source Guide*: https://docs.securedrop.org/en/stable/source.html — opened 2026-11-03 for the sentence quoted in §3.4; the codename mechanism itself is cited from the 2026-09-29 census (SecureDrop, as Strongbox, 2013-05-15) and was not re-read at this revision. The Crime Stoppers tip-number practice is likewise from that census's search summary and was not re-opened.
- CaLP Network, *Glossary of terminology for cash and voucher assistance*, entry *commodity voucher*: https://www.calpnetwork.org/publication/glossary-of-terminology-for-cash-and-voucher-assistance/ — read at 2026-11-03 through a search summary of its online entry, not by opening the page; the *value voucher* entry text was not read.
- Musi/Saimart (Zimbabwe) and Puregold #PurePadala (2015) diaspora grocery vouchers are cited from the 2026-10-01 census and were not re-opened.
- The Dānamahapphala Sutta, AN 7.52 in CST numbering: `s0403m3.mul.xml:1392` and `:1396` (mūla), read with the neighboring lines on 2026-11-03.

Coda

The mechanism is one line long, stated as a subtraction: **remove the redeem operation from the middle of the chain.**

Everything else in this paper — the anonymity that confers rather than protects, the payment that must not happen, the clock that runs only while nobody has been given the thing — follows from taking that one subtraction seriously and refusing to reinstate it when it becomes inconvenient.

A gift that its holder cannot use is not a lesser gift. It is a different one: a kind that makes a person a giver rather than a recipient. *The payer's absence is not a modesty. It is the whole of what the payer gave.*

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